

for sore throats, and is a helpful remedy for diarrhea. Less astringent than its close relative tormentil (*P. erecta*, see *following entry*), it also has a gentler action within the gastrointestinal tract. It is used externally as a lotion or ointment for bleeding hemorrhoids.

Caution Use internally for more no more than 3–4 weeks at a time.

Potentilla erecta syn. *P. tormentilla* (Rosaceae)

Tormentil

Description Downy creeping perennial growing to 4 in (10 cm). Has leaves bearing 5 leaflets, and many 4-petaled yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to temperate regions of Asia and Europe, tormentil thrives in grassy sites and on heaths and moorland. The aerial parts of tormentil are harvested in summer and the root is gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Tormentil contains 15–20% tannins, catechins, ellagitannins, and a phlobaphene.

History & Folklore According to the 17th-century herbalist Nicholas Culpeper, the herb “is most excellent to stay all kinds of fluxes of blood or humours in man or woman, whether it be at nose, mouth, belly, or any wound in the veins or elsewhere.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Containing even more tannins than oak bark (*Quercus robur*, p. 260), all parts of tormentil are strongly astringent, finding use wherever this action is required. The plant makes a beneficial gargle for throat infections, and an effective mouthwash for treating mouth ulcers and infected gums. Tormentil may be taken for conditions that give rise to diarrhea, such as irritable bowel syndrome, colitis, ulcerative colitis, and dysentery, and for rectal bleeding. Applied externally as a lotion or ointment, tormentil helps relieve hemorrhoids (especially those that are bleeding). In the form of a lotion, tormentil is used to help staunch wounds and protect areas of damaged or burned skin.

Caution Use internally for more no more than 3–4 weeks at a time.

Primula veris (Primulaceae)

Cowslip, Primula

Description Hairy perennial growing to 4 in (10 cm). Has a basal rosette of slightly rough oblong leaves. Stems bear clusters of bright yellow, bell-shaped flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Cowslip grows in Europe and western Asia, preferring fields and pastures with chalky soils. The flowers and leaves are gathered in spring and summer; the root in autumn. This increasingly rare plant should not be picked from the wild.

Parts Used Flowers, leaves, root.

Constituents Cowslip contains triterpenoid saponins, flavonoids, phenols, tannins, and a trace of volatile oil. The flavonoids, mainly in the flowers, are antioxidant, anti-inflammatory and antispasmodic. The triterpenoid saponins, which are concentrated in the root (5–10%), are strongly expectorant.



Cowslip has
calming properties.

History & Folklore This plant is so closely associated with springtime that it is known as *primavera* (spring) in Spanish and Italian. Cowslip has long been reputed to preserve beauty. The 16th-century herbalist William Turner wrote: “Some weomen ... sprinkle ye floures of cowslip with whyte wine and after ... wash their faces with that water to ... make them fayre in the eyes of the worlde rather than in the eyes of God, whom they are not afryd to offend.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Cowslip is an underused but valuable plant. The root is strongly expectorant, stimulating a more liquid mucus

and so easing the clearance of phlegm. It is given for chronic coughs, especially those associated with chronic bronchitis and mucus congestion. The root is also thought to be mildly diuretic and antirheumatic and to slow blood clotting. The leaves have similar properties to the root, but are weaker in action. The flowers are believed to be sedative and are recommended for overactivity and sleeplessness, particularly in children. Cowslip flowers' antispasmodic and anti-inflammatory properties make them potentially useful in the treatment of asthma and other allergic conditions.

Cautions Do not take cowslip during pregnancy, if allergic to aspirin, or if taking anticoagulant medication. Excessive doses can cause vomiting and diarrhea.

Prunella vulgaris (Lamiaceae)

Self-Heal

Description Creeping perennial, growing to 20 in (50 cm) tall, with pointed oval leaves and violet-blue or pink flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, self-heal can be found in temperate regions worldwide. It is a wayside plant, growing in meadows and by roadsides, and thrives in sunny areas. Rarely cultivated, self-heal can easily be grown from seed or by root division. The aerial parts are picked in summer when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Self-heal contains entacyclic triterpenes, tannins, caffeic and rosmarinic acids, and vitamins B₁, C, and K.

History & Folklore As its name indicates, self-heal has been used for centuries to staunch bleeding and heal wounds. The 17th-century herbalist John Gerard wrote: “there is not a better wounde herbe in the world than that of selfe-heale.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Self-heal is an undervalued astringent and wound-healer with tonic activity. In common with other members of the mint family, such as rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128) and sage (*Salvia* spp., p. 131), it has powerful antioxidant and tissue-protective activity—making it potentially of value in many chronic illnesses. Its antioxidant and astringent activity makes it beneficial in conditions such as sore throat, inflammatory bowel disease, and diarrhea, and to heal internal bleeding. Externally, a lotion can be applied to treat leukorrhea (vaginal discharge). In Chinese medicine, self-heal is taken with *ju hua* (*Chrysanthemum x morifolium*, p. 78) for fevers, headaches, dizziness, and vertigo, and is thought to cool “liver fire.”